

SURVMETH 670
Survey Design Seminar
Winter 2026

INSTRUCTORS

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CLASS MEETINGS

9:30 AM - 12:00 PM Thursdays, 1070 ISR-Thompson (Michigan) and 1208 Lefrak Hall (Maryland), starting January 8, 2026

PRE-REQUISITES

Completion of courses in applied sampling and data collection methods OR completion of an introduction to survey methodology course OR permission of instructors.

COURSE CONTENT

The Survey Design Seminar is a practical training element for students in the University of Maryland's Joint Program in Survey Methodology and the University of Michigan's Program in Survey and Data Science Masters' degree programs. It prepares students to work with real-world clients on methodological problems as they develop skills in consulting for survey design, data collection, analysis, and data science. Instruction is provided in consulting skills, professional presentations, developing research proposals in response to requests for proposals, and professional conduct.

COURSE EXPECTATIONS

This course meets weekly simultaneously at the University of Maryland and the University of Michigan. Typical class sessions are two and one-half hours and usually include lecture and discussion. For the client and student presentation sessions (see *Team Assignments* below) on January 22, February 26, and April 2, class sessions are expected to be at least three hours.

Regular attendance at class sessions is required, and in-person attendance at all class sessions is a requirement of the program. If a student is unable to attend a particular class session, they are required to notify the instructors via email at least 15 minutes before the start of the class session.

This is a two-campus course, and the instructors are both at the University of Michigan. They each expect to travel to the University of Maryland once during the semester.

The course will utilize the University of Michigan Canvas course site system. Each student will be registered on the Michigan Canvas system. The course web site will include weekly overviews of what is expected for the coming week, materials to be read for class, the course daily schedule, assignments, facilities for submission of assignments, and facilities for return of marked assignments.

Given the nature of the instructor advising role with each team (see below), instructors will not post specific office hours. Students wanting to meet with an instructor, individually or as a team, should schedule appointments by email or in person.

Client Consulting Team Project

The instructors have recruited six clients (see Client Summaries below) with methodological projects that need survey and data science expert consulting. The course web site has folders with background materials provided by each client. All students are expected, as part of ungraded Task 1, to read the background material for each client before the first class session on January 8. This background reading should serve as the basis for each student's first and second client preference. Teams will be formed as much as possible on the basis of first preference. In cases where too many students prefer a particular client, instructors will first select students to be moved to another client as their second preference. If second preference cannot be met either, then randomly selected students will be assigned to a team to balance the size of the teams.

Teams will be formed with students from both campuses. Teams will be responsible for organizing team meetings and designating team members to interact with the client. Each team will have one of the two instructors as a team adviser throughout the consulting process.

Clients will be invited to a regular class session (January 22) to make a presentation about the methodological problem they would like addressed. All students will attend all client presentations. During and after the team's client presentation, the team members will be expected to interact with the client, asking questions and attempting to understand fully the nature of the client's methodological problems.

Following the initial client meeting, instructors will meet with teams weekly in and outside of class to advise them about such tasks as developing conceptual understandings of the client's problem, operationalizing conceptual measures, developing proposals on how to address client problems, reviewing relevant literature, developing a presentation of the team ideas, and so on. Instructors will be available for individual appointments with students on an "as needed" basis.

On February 26, clients will be invited back to the classroom to hear a preliminary 15 to 20-minute presentation by the team. On April 2, students will make a final 20-minute presentation to the client. In most cases, the students will submit to the client a set of slides outlining the results of their review, summarizing investigations, and discussing recommendations. There may be additional products such as a bibliography, draft questionnaire, or a sample design. Each student must give part of either the preliminary or final presentation.

The following is a brief summary of the client projects; fuller descriptions are on the Canvas site:

Design surveys in two African countries concerning attitudes toward dual citizenship.

We are designing a multi-country survey in West Africa on public opinions of dual citizenship. Prior research on these themes has been largely concentrated in the global North; recent experiences across Africa, however, demonstrate the potential contentiousness of citizens holding two nationalities on a variety of political and economic outcomes. A number of African governments have recently moved to either restrict or liberalize dual nationality policies, while there is also considerable variation in public support for these policies. In addition, over half of African countries prevent elected officials from holding multiple nationalities; in several cases, incumbent regimes have prevented opposition politicians with dual citizenship from running for office in the first place. Our project aims to probe when and why citizens support dual citizenship and whether nationality laws affecting political office holders shape popular perceptions of the democratic process more broadly. The surveys are planned for two countries – Côte d'Ivoire and Liberia

Evaluate the result of experiments to increase response rates. The American Speech-Language-Hearing Association (ASHA) is a professional and credentialing association which currently has approximately 241,000 members and affiliates who are audiologists, speech-language pathologists, speech, language, and hearing scientists, audiology and speech-language pathology assistants, and students. The Surveys and Analysis Team (SAT) conducts 75-100 online surveys, 1-2 paper/pencil surveys, and several focus groups each year, with our members comprising almost all of the survey participants. As with most survey researchers, we have experienced a decline in survey participation over the last decade, especially within the last five years. We have completed many methodological experiments over the past few years that can include changes to messaging, modality, data collection methods, and reporting with the goal of increasing the engagement of our members in the survey process. However, we have only evaluated the success of these methods in isolation within a given survey and fielding year. We would like to look at these experiments more holistically and determine some overall recommendations related to improving member engagement in our surveys.

Assessing the Effectiveness of Alternative Contact and Recruitment Strategies for Survey Respondents.

The Health and Retirement Survey (HRS) is a longitudinal panel study that began in 1992 at the Survey Research Center. It is a national sample of adults over the age of 50 and their spouses in the United States, and every six years a new birth cohort of adults aged 51-56 is recruited into the panel to replenish the sample. The project seeks to develop a data collection protocol that will be applied in the recruitment and interviewing of these MGX persons between 2027 and 2028. We are open to the discussion of potential experiments designed to optimize the data collection protocol, since this fresh probability sample will be released in a series of sample replicates (each of which will be worked within a defined time window of 4-6 months). The project has provided a list of topics and challenges on which we would like to consult with the PSDS students.

Evaluating the Usability of an Online Survey Instrument in Crisis Circumstances

The Panel Study of Income Dynamics (PSID) is one of the longest running surveys conducted by the Survey Research Center in ISR. Across almost six decades of data collection from an original sample and the succeeding generations of family members, the mode of interviewing has moved from face-to-face interviews with paper and pencil questionnaires to telephone interviews employing CATI systems to now employing an online questionnaire. The PSID research team is interested in an initial look at usability issues with the online application and how it may affect data quality. The purpose of this project would be to conduct the first steps of a more systematic usability review. This would involve further testing of the web instrument and a quantitative analysis of paradata such as interview timings and break off points. The student team would interact with the PSID leadership team and SMP faculty.

Analyze a Membership Survey and Suggest Strategies for Membership Engagement and Participation. The Ann Arbor Rotary Club has a recent membership survey they would like analyzed, with the results converted to a strategy for continued membership engagement and survey response. They are interested in answers for the following questions, based on the analysis:

Which groups of members are most engaged or least engaged? How can we improve member engagement and retention? How can we recruit and retain members, especially younger professionals? How can future surveys be improved? What questions or formats would yield more actionable data? Can we design a strategy for ongoing feedback and improvement?

Development of a Cross-national Survey of Consumer Attitudes. Survey Monkey is interested in developing survey items to measure consumer attitudes with a cross-national perspective. A client doing a project for a news organization wants to develop a survey to understand consumers' personal financial sentiment today to develop into targeted

articles for media publication. Their hypothesis is that consumers across various countries (specifically the US, UK, Canada and Australia) are experiencing financial strain, and need data to support this narrative.

Their main question is: how are consumers feeling about their personal finances today? They are looking for a comprehensive dive across various angles, including sentiment surrounding or related to job security, day-to-day spending, emergency savings and retirement. The client wants major life milestones taken into account, for example differences in sentiment and financial planning across gender, generations, and countries.

Individual Proposal Writing Project

In the last third of the course, students will develop and write a response to a Request for Proposals (RFP) provided by the instructors. This will be an individual and not a team project activity. That is, students may **not** collaborate with other students on the development or writing of their proposal, and each student will receive an individual and not a team score for the proposal project (see “Grades” below).

The instructors will post the RFP on the Canvas site on March 19 (see Syllabus below). Students will read the RFP and one week later submit any questions they have to clarify the nature of the project described in the RFP. During the March 26 class session, the instructors will host a “Bidders’ Conference” where they will answer student questions.

Bidders’ Conference questions and answers will also be posted on Canvas after the April 9 class session. In addition, instructors will post three tools on Canvas to help students develop and write their proposals: 1) a survey design checklist and proposal outline covering the core elements students should consider in their proposal; 2) a GANTT chart spreadsheet template for recording tasks and their timelines for delivery; and 3) a budget spreadsheet template students can use to develop a budget for their proposal.

The instructors will be available at the April 9 class session to answer student questions about their proposals. The individual student proposals are due April 15 and will be submitted via Canvas.

TEXTBOOK AND READING

The principal text is *Statistical Consulting*, by Javier Cabrera and Andrew McDougall (Springer Science+ Business Media, 2002). You should focus on chapters 1 through 6 and 9, as indicated in the syllabus, referred to as C&M. This is an ebook that you can access through the University of Michigan Library. A second reading source is Alan Weiss, *Getting Started in Consulting* (Wiley, 4th Edition 2019), also available online and for purchase as an ebook, as indicated in the syllabus as AW

Additional readings on consulting in statistical practice are also available in the Canvas Files folder “Readings.” Reading assignments should be completed before class.

GRADING

Students will be evaluated on a number of team assignments and one individual assignment. Each team is responsible for one student submitting team assignments such as the preliminary and final presentation slide sets. Instructors will assign scores for each assignment to all team members.

Most team submissions will be graded as check-plus (100), check (90), check-minus (80), and not submitted (0). Marked team submissions are due on the date indicated in the syllabus and will ordinarily be returned before the next class session.

The preliminary and final presentations will each be scored on a 100-point basis. These presentation scores will not use the “check” marking system.

The final project is an individual assignment to develop and write a proposal in response to a request for proposals (RFP), and it will be scored on a 100-point basis.

There are seven ungraded tasks that all students are expected to complete.

The final grade will be a weighted average of scores on the average of six team submissions (20% total), the team preliminary presentation (10%), the team final presentation (20%), and the individual proposal (50%).

Near the end of the course, students will also complete a peer evaluation rating of the individual contributions that other team members made to the completion of the team project. If the peer evaluations for an individual are strong, unadjusted individual team score averages will be used to determine final grades. Otherwise, the instructors will adjust an individual’s average team score downward to reflect less than adequate contributions to the team project.

Students may, no less than one hour before a submission is due, request permission to submit team or individual assignments late. Late submission permission is not guaranteed but is generally granted. If a submission is late, and there is no prior permission, team assignment or individual scores will be reduced by 30 points. Missing or incomplete assignments receive a score of zero.

Academic Misconduct

The University of Michigan community functions best when its members treat one another with honesty, fairness, respect, and trust. The college promotes the assumption of personal responsibility and integrity and prohibits all forms of academic dishonesty and misconduct. Being found responsible for academic misconduct will usually result in a grade sanction.

Students are expected to adhere to the ethical standards at their respective university where they are registered. In general, instructors consider the presence of a student's name on a document as the student's pledge that the work presented is theirs alone. University academic integrity policies at both campuses have clear definitions of academic misconduct, including cheating and plagiarism, as well as disciplinary sanctions for academic misconduct. Cases of misconduct will be handled according to the respective campus rules and policies.

Knowledge of these rules and policies is the responsibility of the student. Ignorance or lack of familiarity does not excuse misconduct.

Use of ChatGPT and other AI Tools

Instructors in this course may ask you to provide evidence of your learning through written work. When they do, the writing you submit must be of your own creation. Your writing will naturally be informed by other written work. When it is, you must be sure to acknowledge this influence through appropriate citation.

In the past, the 'other written work' was always created by another human. These days, artificial intelligence (AI) tools can be used to generate text, code, and images in response to a prompt. Such automatically generated text is not your work and cannot be submitted as if it is.

Work generated by AI tools like ChatGPT is a source that may inform your writing, just as books, papers, lecture notes, websites, and the results of Google searches can. As always, it's your responsibility to assess the reliability of every source you use. In that context, you should be aware that the output of AI tools is constructed to sound plausible, and not checked by any expert. These results are often completely invented.

Course Recordings

Course lectures may be audio/video recorded and made available to other students in this course. As part of your participation in this course, you may be recorded. If you do not wish to be recorded, please contact either instructor the first week of class (or as soon as you enroll in the course, whichever is latest) to discuss alternative arrangements.

Additional information regarding course recordings and privacy concerns can be found on the UM ITS Recording and Privacy Concerns webpage.

Disability Statement

The University of Michigan recognizes disability as an integral part of diversity and is committed to creating an inclusive and equitable educational environment for students with disabilities. Your instructors invite students who need assistance to request it.

Students who are experiencing a disability-related barrier should contact Services for Students with Disabilities (<https://ssd.umich.edu/>

[Links to an external site.](#); 734-763-3000 or ssdoffice@umich.edu . For students who are connected with SSD, accommodation requests can be made in Accommodate. If you have any questions or concerns, please contact your SSD Coordinator or visit SSD's Current Student webpage. SSD considers aspects of the course design, course learning objects and the individual academic and course barriers experienced by the student. Further conversation with SSD, instructors, and the student may be warranted to ensure an accessible course experience.

The instructors have been the work to make the Canvas website for the course satisfy the requirements of Title II of the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA). This is an ongoing process to meet deadline currently set for April 2026.

Mental Health and Well-Being

University students may experience stressors that can impact both their academic experience and their personal well-being. These may include academic pressures and challenges associated with relationships, mental health, alcohol or other drugs, identities, finances, etc. If you are experiencing concerns, seeking help is a courageous thing to do for yourself and those who care about you. If the source of your stressors is academic, please contact us so that we can find solutions together. For personal concerns, U-M offers a variety of resources, many which are listed on the Resources for Student Well-being webpage (<https://wellbeing.umich.edu/tools-resources/>). You can also search for additional well-being resources on that website. The University of Maryland has similar resources, which can be found at <https://studentaffairs.umd.edu/health-wellness>.

Sexual Misconduct Policy

Title IX prohibits discrimination on the basis of sex, which includes sexual misconduct — including harassment, domestic and dating violence, sexual assault, and stalking. We understand that sexual violence can undermine students' academic success, and we encourage anyone dealing with sexual misconduct to talk to someone about their experience, so they can get the support they need. Confidential support and academic advocacy can be found with the Sexual Assault Prevention and Awareness Center (SAPAC) on their 24-hour crisis line, 734.936.3333, and at sapac@umich.edu.

Alleged violations can be non-confidentially reported to the Equity, Civil Rights, and Title IX Office (ECRT) at ecrtooffice@umich.edu. The University of Maryland has similar policies, available at <https://policies.umd.edu/general-administration/university-of-maryland-policy-and-procedures-on-sexual-harassment-and-other-sexual-misconduct>.

Student Parents and Caregivers

If you are pregnant, a parenting student, or primarily responsible for providing care for a loved one or family member, and you are in need of any accommodations, please let the instructors know at your earliest convenience. You may also reach out to mcasp.org and CEW+ for resources and community support. The University of Maryland has similar policies, available at <https://www.umaryland.edu/ssle/student-success-center/student-resources/resources-for-student-parents-and-caregivers/>.

Online Course Evaluations

Both universities have online student course evaluation systems. All students are urged to use the online course evaluation system at the end of the term, since course evaluations will only be available to other students when a required minimum number of registered students complete the evaluation.

Classroom Schedule

Week 1 (Jan 8)

Lecture/Discussion: *Course introduction. Understanding client problems & needs, forming client relationships, managing client meetings.*

Task 1: Mark initial project preference on Canvas Assignment document for Task 1.

Reading: Arndt & Woolson (1991), Kauermann & Weihs (2007), Kirk(1991), Marquardt (1979), Moses & Louis (1984), Stegman (1985), Turner(1982), Zahn & Isenberg (1983).

Instructors: ME/MT

Week 2 (Jan 15)

Lecture/Discussion: *Types of consulting and problem-solving arrangements, work initiation, responding to requests.*

Reading: AW (pp. 281-289, Appendix H), Orr & Orr (2013) Chapters 2, 3, 5, 6, and 8.

Instructor: MT

Week 3 (Jan 22)

Client presentations: *Clients make presentations & answer student questions.*

Assignment 1 (Due Jan 21): Client research questions

Task 2: Participate as consultant

Task 3: Final client preferences (Due Jan 23)

Instructors: ME/MT

Week 4: (Jan 29)

Lecture/Discussion: *Project management -- organizing work, hiring staff, work location, setting up an office, organizing a literature review.*

Assignment 2 (Due Feb 6): 250-word memo summarizing client research questions, hypotheses, approach to the problem, task list, and schedule for each task.

Reading: AW (pp. 23-44, Chapter 2), Prewitt (1983), Prewitt (2008)

Instructor: MT

Week 5: (Feb 5):

Lecture/Discussion: *Alternative quantitative & qualitative research designs, reviewing prior work, strengths & weaknesses of using existing data vs. implementing new data collection and secondary analysis vs. original data, sources of questions, data comparability vs. better measurement.*

Meet instructor mentors during class.

Assignment 3 (Due Feb 6): *Two-page double-spaced progress report.*

Reading: Borenstein, Hedges & Rothstein (2007), Smets & van Ham (2013).

Instructor: MT

Week 6: (Feb 12)

Student Presentations: Students present in-progress work to clients and receive client feedback.

Assignment 4 (Due February 9): *Student preliminary presentation final slides for group meeting with instructor*

Instructor: ME

Week 7: (Feb 19)

Discussion. *Review preliminary student presentations and client feedback*

Assignment 5 : *Student comments on preliminary presentation in a two-page memo*

Instructors: ME/MT

Week 8: (Feb 26)

Lecture/Discussion. *Ethical issues in data collection, storage, management, reporting publishing, authorship, & copyright. Securing confidentiality, anonymity.*

Reading: Miller (2005), Jacques (2013), Chapter 11 in Groves et al (2009), Lacour & Green (2014), Broockman et al. (2015), Foster(2015), Gelman (2015), MIT Economics (2025), NAS Authorship, IP, & Handling Data(2009), Oakes (2012), Singal (2015), Stanford Best Practices in Science (2025), Starbuck (2013), Statistical Modeling (2025), Thomas & Quinn (1991).

Task 4: Download & review mock RFP (available 5 PM, March 19).

Task 5: Submit questions for Bidders' Conference (March 23)

Instructor: ME

Week 9: (Mar 12) No class; Michigan winter term break.

Week 10 (Mar 19)

Lecture/Discussion: *Understanding and responding to RFP's -- preparing budgets, budgeting (IDC, payment schedules), work plans, and structuring a proposal.*

Reading: AW (pp. 146-172, Chapter 7); Jacques, Chapters 4-7, 11; University of Michigan Library System, "Research Funding and Grants Guide"
(https://guides.lib.umich.edu/c.php?g=283405&p=1887268&utm_source=library-search).

Instructor: ME/MT

Week 11: (Mar 26)

Second Practice for client presentations: (9:30-10:45)

Bidders' Conference (10:45-11:30)

Assignment 6 (Due Mar 26): Student preliminary presentation draft slides; student comments.

Instructors post Bidders Conference questions and answers, design checklist/proposal outline, Gantt chart template, and budget template.

Assignment 7 (Due Mar 26): Attend bidders' conference.

Instructors: ME/MT

Week 12: (Apr 2) Student Final Presentations to client & client feedback.

Task 6 (Due April 2): Final presentation to clients.

Instructors: ME/MT

Week 13: (Apr 9) Discuss final products for clients and closing projects out

Discuss RFP development: *Instructors answer questions about student proposals being developed.*

Instructors: ME/MT

Week 14: (Apr 16) No class

Assignment 8 (Due Apr 16): Final work product for client

Task 7: *Teammate evaluations (Due April9).*

Instructors: ME/MT

Apr 15: Final individual project due (Response to the RFP)

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Concise Course Schedule

Date	Details	Due
Thu Jan 8, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Task 1:	Initial project preferences	
Thu Jan 15, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Thu Jan 22, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Assignment 0:	PEERRS Certification, ISR Confidentiality Pledge	due by 9:30am
Assignment 1:	Client research questions (Due Jan 21)	due by 9:30am
Task 2:	Student-consultant interaction with the client	due by 9:30am
Task 3:	Final client preferences (Due Jan 23)	due by 11:59pm
Thu Jan 29, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Assignment 2:	Meet with mentor, initial research plan memo	due by 9:30am
Thu Feb 5, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Assignment 3:	Two-page double spaced progress report (Due Feb 6)	
Thu Feb 12, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Assignment 4:	Prepare preliminary slides (Due Feb 9 by 12pm)	
Thu Feb 19, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Assignment 5:	Student comments on preliminary presentation	due by 1pm
Thu Feb 26, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Assignment 6:	Make initial client presentation	due by 9:30am
Thu Mar 12, 2026	No class – Michigan Winter Break	
Thu Mar 15, 2026	Task 4: Download mock RFP	Available by 5pm
Thu Mar 19, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Assignment 6:	Submit draft slides for final Client Presentation	due by 9am
Task 5:	Submit Bidder Conference questions by Mar 23	due by 9am
Thu Mar 26, 2026	Practice session for client presentations	9:30 to 10:45am
Assignment 7:	Attend the Bidders Conference	10:45 to 12pm

Assignment 8	File upload test	due by 5pm
Thu Apr 2, 2026	Calendar Event SURVMETH 670 101 WN 2026	9:30am to 12pm
Task 6:	Final presentations to clients	9:30 am to 12 pm
Mon Apr 6, 2026	Assignment 8: Work Products for Clients	due by 11:59pm
Assignment Task 7:	Teammate evaluations (Due April 9)	due by 11:59pm
Thu Apr 9, 2026	Final products for clients, close out projects	9:30am to 12pm
Thu Apr 16, 2026	No class	9:30am to 12pm
Assignment 9:	Upload response to the RFP	due by 11:59pm